Out in the Cold

Before Honecker had a chance to settle into a comfortable retirement, an early whiff of recrimination came on 23 October when the SED's chief ideologist Kurt Hager, issued the first public criticism of the former General Secretary, stating that elements of a personality cult had surrounded him, 'there had been a tendency to give Honecker sole credit for the country's achievements in areas such as peace and disarmament'.1 Ironically, at a Politburo meeting a day earlier, it had been agreed to arrange an 'extensive celebration in honour of Honecker'. But now events were moving fast.2 In later life, Honecker vehemently denied he was the focus of a personality cult. 'I arranged that no stamps would be printed with my picture,' he asserted, adding:

I never put any value on popularising photographs of me. Once at the Leipzig fair there were forty-two pictures of me published in Neues Deutschland. They were published because on all the stands the ambassadors stood with me, as well as ministers of the most diverse governments. That was shown afterward to be wrong, such things should not have been started at all.

3

Meanwhile, under pressure from all directions, Krenz offered to ease travel restrictions, mistakenly believing this would calm protestors who remained on the streets across the GDR.4 Demonstrators did not budge however, even after the much-publicised resignation of Margot Honecker. (In a letter dated 20 October 1989, Margot asked the Council of Ministers to release